second at Kolkata, starting on 28 November, brought a very satisfying victory, with Bhajji proving a match-winner again, this time taking seven wickets in the South African second innings.

Even though I was still not fully fit, my contribution was gradually improving and by the time of the first match in a two-Test series in Bangladesh in December, I was in good enough form to make my highest Test score – 248 not out – at Dhaka. It was also my thirty-fourth Test hundred, equalling Sunil Gavaskar's world-record tally. He was actually commentating in Bangladesh at the time and he kindly sent me a fabulous gift of thirty-four bottles of champagne to make it a truly memorable day in my career.

## The elbow surgery

In March 2005 Pakistan were scheduled to visit us at home for three Tests and seven ODIs. It was a tour I really did not want to miss and I pushed myself as hard as I could, trying to ignore the soreness, but I eventually realized that I was struggling for form and I wasn't doing my elbow any good. It was time to face the prospect of surgery, something I'd hoped to avoid.

The procedure was carried out on 25 May 2005 and I was told it would be four and a half months before I could hold a cricket bat. Those months were extremely difficult. I couldn't help worrying that my career might be over and would often pray to God that my career should not come to an end like this. It was very frustrating not doing anything and at one point I hung a ball in a sock below our apartment and tried doing some shadow practice with a plastic bat, but even that was really painful. The last two months were the hardest. I could barely sleep and would have to go out for long drives in the middle of the night with my friend Faisal Momen just to try and calm down a little.

The first games I played after the surgery were in a domestic competition, the limited-overs Challenger Trophy in Mohali in October 2005. The elbow was not completely back to normal but I felt it was time to try it out. In my very first day of practice I experienced some pain in my shoulder after a throw. Here I was recovering from left elbow surgery and now my right shoulder was hurting. I put it down to my prolonged absence from the game and went ahead with the games, but the pain